UOA LEGAL

Frisco, TX | New York, NY

Matter Lifecycle Framework

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1. Ground rules

- **First step.** Before building, walk the 2–3 real matters (names removed) end to end against this map and return your redline.
- **No personal data.** Samples A and B below are anonymized. No client names, A-numbers, receipt numbers, dates of birth, addresses, employers, or case facts appear here, and none belong in your notes, tickets, test data, or code. Use "Matter A", "Matter B", and role labels only.
- **Defaults.** Items tagged [Confirm] are working defaults that Udoka has not yet ruled on. Build them as configuration, not hard-coded behavior.
- **Audit trail.** Every stage change is an event with an owner and a timestamp. If it is not logged, it did not happen.

2. The spine: one lifecycle for every matter

Petition, application, and litigation matters share the same eleven stages. Only the forum, forms, and deadlines change.

#	Stage	Exit gate (must be true to advance)	Owner	System event
1	Intake and conflicts	Conflict check cleared. Matter typed (petition / application / EOIR litigation / federal). Urgency flag set (removal date, detention, hard deadline).	Intake, then Attorney	matter.created
2	Engagement	Signed retainer. Scope, fee phases, and client-versus-firm responsibilities recorded.	Attorney only	engagement.signed
3	Strategy and eligibility	Attorney memo: pathway, risks, evidence plan. Deadline calendar built and attorney-verified.	Attorney only	strategy.approved
4	Evidence build	Every checklist item has an owner (client, firm, or third party) and a status. All items received or drafted.	Paralegal, client	evidence.complete
5	Review and sign-off	Final legal review done. Signatures collected. Filing packet locked.	Attorney only	packet.locked
6	Appearance and filing	G-28 or EOIR-28 filed with the packet. Method, fee, and proof of filing or service captured.	Filing clerk; Attorney signs	filing.submitted
7	Receipt and monitoring	Receipt or acknowledgment logged within 1 business day. Tracking and deadlines switched on.	Docketing	receipt.logged
8	Agency action	RFE, NOID, biometrics, interview, hearing, or order: logged, calendared, and routed to the attorney the same day.	Docketing, then Attorney	notice.received
9	Decision	Outcome logged. Client told by the attorney, not by the system.	Attorney	decision.recorded
10	Post-decision	Approval delivery, or a motion / appeal / refile decision with a hard deadline.	Attorney	postdecision.opened

#	Stage	Exit gate (must be true to advance)	Owner	System event
11	Closure	Closure checklist complete. Closing letter sent.	Attorney approves	matter.closed

3. Answers to the four added questions

Q1. After filing, how do notices reach us, and who catches them?

- **One intake.** Every agency channel feeds one controlled docket, never an individual inbox: USCIS paper notices to the firm address on the G-28; USCIS attorney online account alerts and receipt-number status checks; EOIR ECAS email notifications and portal; DHS service by ECAS or mail.
- **Who catches it.** A named Docketing owner, with a named backup, checks every channel daily. Each notice is logged within 1 business day, its deadline is extracted, and it is routed to the attorney of record the same day. A notice with no calendared deadline is treated as not yet logged.
- **Client copy is not firm notice.** Do not rely on the client to forward notices. Request original notices to the attorney and a copy to the client on the G-28, and tell clients to forward anything they receive the same day.
- **Backstop.** A weekly automated sweep checks status on every open receipt number and flags any matter with no activity past its expected processing window.

Q2. Who is attorney of record, and who files G-28s?

- **Attorney of record.** One attorney of record per matter, named on the appearance form. [Confirm] Udoka on every matter until a second attorney joins.
- **Two forms, two systems.** G-28 covers USCIS, CBP, and ICE/DHS. EOIR-28 covers the immigration court and the BIA. They are not interchangeable: a G-28 does not authorize an appearance before EOIR, and each EOIR forum needs its own appearance.
- **Who files.** Staff prepare the form. Only the attorney signs. A G-28 accompanies each new form filed at USCIS (for example, a later motion or appeal needs its own). The appearance is filed with the first filing in that forum. [Confirm] whether staff get delegated access to the attorney's ECAS and USCIS online accounts.
- **Ending it.** An appearance ends only by formal withdrawal or substitution, never by silence. The system tracks every open appearance by forum.

Q3. How and when does a file close?

- **Four close paths.** Approval or grant delivered and acknowledged; denial with the client's written decision and the appeal window expired; termination by client or firm; or dormancy after two written notices with no response.
- **Closure checklist.** No open deadline. No pending agency action. Trust account reconciled. Original documents returned. Appearance withdrawn where required. Closing letter sent, stating that representation has ended and listing any dates the client must still handle (conditions, expirations, renewals).
- **Scope.** A successful outcome does not extend the matter. The next phase (for example, adjustment after an approved petition, or the merits case after a reopening) opens as a new matter with its own retainer. [Confirm]
- **Retention.** Store close date and a destroy-after date. [Confirm] retention period under the NY and TX rules.

Q4. Which steps today only Udoka can do?

These become hard attorney gates. The system routes work to the gate and blocks progress until the attorney approves. It never performs the step itself.

- Conflict clearance, accepting the matter, and fee and retainer terms.
- Pathway selection, eligibility opinions, and risk advice.
- Signing as attorney: G-28, EOIR-28, briefs, legal arguments, and final review of expert and employer letters.

- Authorizing the filing (packet lock) and any ECAS or USCIS online-account submission under his credentials.
- Advising on RFE, NOID, and denial responses, and deciding whether to appeal, move to reopen, or refile.
- Trust account disbursements and refunds; withdrawal and closure.

Everything else (intake logistics, checklist chasing, drafting from templates, packet assembly, docketing, status sweeps, reminders) is delegable under attorney supervision. That is where the build effort pays off.

4. Worked samples (anonymized)

Matter A is a petition-track matter that includes an RFE and a denial, so the map handles the unhappy path. Matter B is a litigation-track matter with a hard clock from day one.

Stage	Matter A: EB-2 National Interest Waiver petition	Matter B: Motion to reopen a removal order (EOIR)
1 Intake	Prospect CV and credentials reviewed. Preliminary assessment letter issued with an express "no attorney-client relationship until retainer" statement.	Same-day triage: forum (court or BIA), type and date of order, prior motions, any scheduled removal or detention. Deadline computed immediately.
2 Engagement	Two-phase flat fee. Written split of responsibilities: client sources third-party experts; firm drafts opinion letters for experts to sign.	Limited-scope retainer for the motion only. EOIR-28 prepared for signature.
3 Strategy	Three-prong national-interest analysis. Threshold check: advanced degree or equivalent through five years of progressive experience, with exceptional ability as the alternative track.	Choose the basis (for example lack of notice, exceptional circumstances, changed conditions, new eligibility for relief). Check time and number limits and whether a stay request is needed.
4 Evidence	Business plan, employer verification letters (dates, full or part time, pay, title, duties), expert letters, policy and market evidence, recommendation letters.	Declarations, supporting documents, and the relief application the motion would rely on.
5 Sign-off	Attorney reviews every expert letter and the cover brief. Packet locked.	Attorney reviews motion and exhibits. Packet locked.
6 Filing	I-140 with G-28. [Confirm] premium processing election.	E-file through ECAS with EOIR-28. Proof of service on DHS counsel captured.
7 Monitoring	Receipt notice logged. Status sweep on the receipt number.	ECAS notifications. DHS response window and any stay status tracked.
8 Agency action	RFE logged with its response date. Possible NOID. Biometrics or interview notices do not usually apply to this petition type.	DHS opposition, hearing notice, order, or detention or bond event.
9 Decision	Approval or denial recorded. Attorney informs client.	Granted or denied. Attorney informs client.
10 Post-decision	If denied: motion to reconsider or reopen on Form I-290B within the appeal window, or refile on a rebuilt record. If approved: hand off.	If denied: appeal to the BIA or petition for review in the circuit court, each on a short fixed clock. If granted: case resets to a merits track.
11 Closure	Close on approval delivered, or on the client's written decision after the window expires. Follow-on filings open as new matters.	Close only after appeal windows expire. A grant opens a new merits matter rather than closing.

Deadline reference (configure, do not hard-code)

Event	Typical window	Build note
USCIS RFE response	Up to 12 weeks from notice	Fixed date on the notice controls. No extensions are generally available.
USCIS NOID response	30 days (plus 3 if mailed)	Date on the notice controls.
Form I-290B (appeal or motion)	30 days from decision (plus 3 if mailed)	Compute from the decision date, not the receipt date.
EOIR motion to reopen	Generally 90 days from final order; one motion	Exceptions exist (lack of notice, in absentia rescission, changed country conditions). Attorney sets the rule per matter.
BIA appeal from an IJ decision	30 days	Fixed date. Escalate early.
Circuit court petition for review	30 days from BIA order	Fixed date. Escalate early.

Every computed deadline carries an "attorney-verified" flag and a mailing-extension toggle. Windows change, so each must be re-verified by the attorney before it is relied on.

5. Data model and rules

Entities: Matter, Party (role only), Appearance (form, forum, status), Filing, Notice (channel, received_at, logged_at, type), Deadline (trigger date, rule, computed due date, verified flag), Task (owner role), Gate (attorney approval with timestamp), Document, Event log.

- **R1.** A logged notice must create a Deadline or an attorney-recorded "no deadline" flag.
- **R2.** Deadlines escalate to the attorney and the backup at 21, 14, 7, 3, and 1 days.
- **R3.** Stages 2, 3, 5, and 6 cannot advance without an attorney gate approval.
- **R4.** A matter cannot close with an open deadline or an open appearance.
- **R5.** Keep personal data in an isolated, encrypted store. Workflow logic runs on synthetic matter IDs, and dev and test environments never contain real client data.

6. Next step: validate against real matters

Walk each of the 2–3 real matters end to end against stages 1–11. For each stage, record who touched it, what notice or document moved, where the matter stalled, and what this map failed to predict. Return a redline of this document. Build work starts once the redline is accepted.

Udoka's open decisions: attorney of record once a second attorney joins; delegated ECAS and USCIS account access; premium processing handling; retention period.